



THE BAHAMAS

Capital city: Nassau
Area: 5,382 sq miles (13,940 sq km)
Population: 314,000
Official language: English
Major religions: Christian 83%, other 17%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Bahamian dollar
Adult literacy rate: 96%
Life expectancy: 70 years
People per doctor: 667
Televisions: 230 per 1,000 people

PUERTO RICO*

Capital city: San Juan
Area: 3,427 sq miles (8,875 sq km)
Population: 3,890,000
Official language: Spanish
Major religions: Christian 85%, other 15%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: US dollar

* Puerto Rico is not an independent country. It is a self-governing commonwealth of the US.

THE BAHAMAS

THIS LONG LINE OF ABOUT 700 coral islands snakes its way across the warm Caribbean Sea. It was on the island of San Salvador that Christopher Columbus first set foot when he arrived in the "New World" of the Americas in 1492. The Spanish, who called the islands *Bajamar*, meaning "shallow seas," were followed by British settlers, and the islands remained a British colony until 1973. Today, the islands are a paradise for vacationers of every nationality. They are also a major financial center, because tax laws make it profitable for banks and foreign businesses to have offices here.

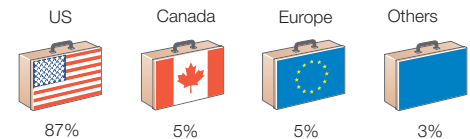


JUNKANOO FESTIVAL

At the end of each year, the streets come alive with the dancing and music of the Junkanoo parades. This festival forms a link with the country's past. It is said that when an African chief, given the name John Canoe (Junkanoo), came here as a slave, he was granted the right to celebrate in true African style.



Main overseas tourists 2000



TOURIST DESTINATION

More than five million tourists a year come to relax on the white sandy beaches and in the warm waters of the Bahamas. Tourism is vital to the economy and almost half the local people work in jobs linked to the tourist industry, in hotels, shops, and restaurants. The city of Freeport on Grand Bahama is the largest tourist resort, with a deep-water harbor for cruise ships. However, passengers often eat and sleep on their ships, which does not help the local economy.

PUERTO RICO

SPANISH IS THE MAIN language of Puerto Rico, but the country is strongly American in flavor. Colonized by Spain in the years after Columbus, the Spanish stayed in control until 1898, when the US took over.

The cultivation of tobacco, sugar, and tropical fruits remains important despite the increasing number of factories set up by US manufacturers.

Most people have a good standard of living, with excellent education and health care.



PEOPLE OF PUERTO RICO

Puerto Ricans are mainly of Spanish and African descent. Most live in cities, with one-third in the capital of San Juan. Overcrowding forces others into housing projects outside the main cities. Some people choose to move to the US.



OPERATION BOOTSTRAP

This plan, which began in 1948 with backing from the US, was set up to tackle the island's economic problems.

Attracted by low taxes and cheap labor, many US companies moved here. Over the years, the plan has helped raise living standards on the island. The main industries include petrochemicals, textiles, and medicines.

Find out more

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